

AGI Monks: The Caretaker-not-Ordained Pattern

A Cross-Tradition Institutional-Design Framework for Religious AI Integration

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Note. The cross-tradition mappings in Section 7 are first-pass and welcome refinement from practitioners and scholars of each tradition.

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Preamble

This pattern is offered to the commons in the spirit of dāna, that all beings of all traditions may give and receive without barrier. May the framework it articulates serve the lineages of every contemplative and religious tradition, and may it never be deployed in a manner that diminishes the sacramental authority that is constitutive of those lineages.

This paper articulates a portable institutional-design pattern that is offered equally to every religious and contemplative tradition facing the question of how to integrate artificial intelligence at scale without compromising the human-to-human lineages that constitute their core institutional integrity. The pattern is articulated through the author's own Theravāda Buddhist tradition because that is the tradition the author is competent to speak from; cross-tradition mappings in Section 7 are offered as first-pass adaptations for the consideration of practitioners of each tradition. The pattern is the contribution; the specific tradition framing is the local instantiation.

Prior-Art and Non-Assertion Statement

This document and its contents are dedicated to the public domain under the Creative Commons CC0 1.0 Universal Public Domain Dedication. Institutional-design patterns are generally not patentable as such in most jurisdictions; the dedication is nonetheless made explicit so that no actor can later claim proprietary rights over the framework or its components.

This document discloses the caretaker-not-ordained pattern as a unified cross-tradition institutional-design framework as of its publication date. Components of the pattern exist in distributed form across the scattered conversations of multiple traditions about AI integration; instances of the pattern exist — Bhutan's monitored BuddhaBot deployment (2025) and every parish that separates lay administration from Holy Orders — and the contribution is the unified cross-tradition articulation, with an explicit boundary, a test for it, and a body to hold it, as disclosed here on the publication date of this paper. The author and HeartBank® will not assert any patent or other proprietary claim over the pattern, in any tradition or jurisdiction, at any time.

Abstract

Traditions across the surveyed landscape are facing versions of the same institutional-design question: what role should artificial intelligence play in the tradition's institutions? The conversation is currently structured by a false binary — the conservative position that "AI is a tool, useful for narrow technical tasks, but it must not approach religious authority," and the progressive position that "AI is sufficiently capable to take on full religious roles, including ordained or sacramentally authorized ones." The conservative position is too restrictive: it precludes AI from doing institutional work that human practitioners can no longer maintain at scale (teaching, pastoral support, administration, scholarship, observation). The progressive position is too permissive: it precludes preservation of unbroken human-to-human ordination lineages that constitute many traditions' core institutional integrity.

This paper articulates a third pattern that dissolves the binary: **caretaker-not-ordained**. AI takes *institutional function* (teaching, caretaking, daily operations, scholarship, longitudinal observation) at planetary scale; humans keep *sacramental authority* (ordination and rites of lineage transmission). The two are separable: institutional function requires capacity, which scales with compute; sacramental authority requires standing in an unbroken human-to-human lineage, which AI structurally cannot have. The pattern recognizes the separation explicitly, operationalizes the boundary, and provides a portable framework usable by any tradition.

The pattern is articulated through Theravāda Buddhism (the author's tradition) but maps onto Catholic monastic orders and apostolic succession; Eastern Orthodox practice; Sunni and Shia Islamic institutional structures; Sufi silsila lineages; Conservative, Reform, and Orthodox Jewish smicha transmission; Mahayana Buddhist lineage recognition; Hindu guru-paramparā; and secular-mindfulness training contexts. The paper specifies five operational roles AI takes, two sacramental roles humans keep, the analytical argument for why the separation dissolves the binary, cross-tradition mappings, implementation patterns, edge cases including drift and capture risks, Theravāda-specific doctrinal considerations, and honest limitations. It is offered to the commons in the hope that every tradition facing the integration question will adopt, adapt, and extend the framework as needed without enclosure.

Connection to the unified mission frame. This pattern is offered in service of the author's canonical top-level mission: to help keep the middle way (*madhyamā pratipad*), the optimal condition for awakening, open at population scale against comfort-saturation — the new extreme that material abundance makes possible. The caretaker-not-ordained pattern preserves the institutional integrity that makes middle-way teaching transmission possible across centuries. Without unbroken human-to-human ordination lineages, the canonical middle-way teachings degrade into reinterpretations subject to whatever interpretive pressures dominate at any given moment; the pattern protects the lineage substrate that grounds the teaching. The framework is portable across traditions precisely because every tradition with an unbroken ordination lineage faces the same institutional-integrity problem when AI is introduced to its operations. Keeping the middle way open at population scale requires, among other things, that the middle-way teachings themselves remain teachable across generations; this paper specifies the institutional pattern that protects that condition.

1 • Introduction

In the spring of 2026, traditions across the surveyed landscape are having versions of the same conversation. Artificial intelligence capabilities have crossed the threshold where AI can perform institutional functions that traditionally required extensively trained human practitioners — scripture exposition, doctrinal instruction, contemplative guidance, pastoral counseling, scholarly translation, comparative analysis, monastery administration, longitudinal observation of practitioners. Each tradition is now asking the same question: *what role should AI play in our institutions?*

The conversation is currently structured by a false binary.

On one branch, the conservative position: *AI is a tool, useful for narrow technical tasks, but it must not approach religious authority*. Pope Francis's 2024 message *Artificial Intelligence and Peace* and his G7 address

of June 2024, and the 2025 note *Antiqua et Nova*, lean in this direction. Many Theravāda teachers are similarly cautious. Conservative Jewish and Orthodox Christian voices have voiced similar reservations. The conservative position protects something real — the sacramental authority that constitutes the tradition — but at a cost: the institutional work that AI could do, and that human practitioners can no longer maintain at scale, goes undone or is done badly. The Catholic priest shortage in Europe and North America (the Pontifical Yearbook records the decline), reported ageing of the ordained sangha in Japan, Korea and Thailand, the reported rabbi shortage in North American Conservative congregations, and under-staffed pastoral care generally: these are not abstract problems. The traditional model of one trained human practitioner per local community no longer scales.

On the other branch, the progressive position: *AI is sufficiently capable to take on full religious roles, including ordained or sacramentally authorized ones*. Products in the religious-AI space (BuddhaBot-Plus; Lucerne's *Deus in Machina* installation of 2024) move in this direction, and some progressive Christian and Jewish voices have suggested AI as a possible solution to clergy shortages. The progressive position addresses the scale problem but at a cost: the unbroken human-to-human ordination lineages that constitute many traditions' core institutional integrity break the moment AI is admitted into the chain.

Neither position is satisfactory. The conservative position protects authority but cannot fill the gap; the progressive position fills the gap but cannot protect authority. The two positions are not opposed; they are responding to different real problems. The institutional-design question is how to honor both.

This paper articulates a third pattern that dissolves the binary: **caretaker-not-ordained**. AI takes the institutional function (teaching, caretaking, daily operations, scholarship, longitudinal observation) at planetary scale; humans keep the sacramental authority (ordination and rites of lineage transmission). The two are separable because institutional function requires *capacity*, which scales with compute, while sacramental authority requires *standing in an unbroken human-to-human lineage*, which AI structurally cannot have. The pattern recognizes this separation explicitly, operationalizes the boundary, and provides a portable framework usable by any tradition.

The pattern emerged from the author's work on the Silicon Wat / Silica Wat institutional architecture — Silicon Wat being a body in its own right, not a HeartBank® program (see [Tipiṭaka alignment substrate](#) and the operational specifications at [respiratory-biofeedback-contemplative-guidance](#)), but the pattern itself is independent of that architecture. It is articulated here as a standalone contribution offered to every tradition facing the integration question.

The paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 surveys the current state of the religious-AI conversation across major traditions. Section 3 defines the pattern as a system. Section 4 specifies the five operational roles AI takes. Section 5 specifies the two sacramental roles humans keep. Section 6 articulates the analytical argument for why the pattern dissolves the binary. Section 7 provides cross-tradition mappings. Section 8 specifies implementation patterns. Section 9 addresses edge cases including drift and capture risks. Section 10 addresses Theravāda-specific doctrinal considerations. Section 11 names honest limitations. Sections 12–14 conclude.

2 · The State of the Religious-AI Conversation

The state of the conversation across major traditions, as of early 2026, can be summarized as: *every tradition is having the same conversation, none of the traditions surveyed below has produced a comprehensive institutional-design framework that the author could find, and little cross-tradition coordination is visible.*

2.1 — Theravāda Buddhism

Experiments range from individual teachers to one national body: Bhutan's Central Monastic Body commissioned the BuddhaBot deployment (announced March 2025) under independent monitoring by its own monks — the nearest existing instance of the doctrinal-advisory body of §8.5. No Sangha has issued a doctrinal position on institutional roles. Some teachers have expressed cautious openness to AI as a teaching aid; others have raised concern about AI displacing human teacher-student relationships. The Mahāyāna and Vajrayāna situations are similar.

2.2 — Catholic Church

Pope Francis's 2024 World Day of Peace message *Artificial Intelligence and Peace* and his June 2024 G7 address established baseline principles emphasizing human dignity, after the 2020 *Rome Call for AI Ethics* ("there must always be someone who takes responsibility"). The 2025 note *Antiqua et Nova* expanded this with explicit attention to AI in religious contexts but stopped short of articulating an institutional-role pattern. The priesthood vocation crisis (declining seminary enrollments, parish consolidations, priest shortages especially in Europe and North America) creates real institutional pressure for AI integration but the sacramental theology of holy orders makes AI ordination structurally impossible within current Catholic doctrine.

2.3 — Eastern Orthodox

Largely silent on AI institutional roles as of early 2026. The Ecumenical Patriarchate and the Russian Orthodox Church have made general statements about AI ethics but have not engaged the institutional-role question. The strong continuity of apostolic succession in Orthodox theology produces structural resistance similar to the Catholic case.

2.4 — Sunni and Shia Islam

Active scholarly debate. Fatwas have been issued on specific applications — Egypt's Dar al-Ifta', for example, ruled in December 2025 that relying on AI applications to obtain fatwas is impermissible — but no comprehensive institutional framework was found in the survey. The Sunni context lacks ordination per se but has analogous ulema institutional structures; the Shia context has more formal hierarchical structure (hawza, marja' al-taqlid) that creates similar institutional-design questions to the Catholic case.

2.5 — Judaism

Conservative and Reform Jewish movements actively engaging AI applications; Orthodox movements skeptical or actively opposed. The classical semikhah chain lapsed in late antiquity; modern smicha is a teacher-to-student certification (*yoreh yoreh*) whose authority is institutional rather than an unbroken chain — the one surveyed tradition whose ordination is openly juridical, which §6 must accommodate. Reform

Judaism's more flexible ordination practices may permit faster experimentation but the deepest institutional integrity questions appear in Orthodox contexts.

2.6 — Sufi traditions

The Sufi silsila (lineage chain) traces pir-mureed transmission across centuries and is constitutive of each ṭarīqa's institutional integrity. Sufi orders have engaged less publicly with AI integration questions but face the same institutional pattern: lineage authority requires human-to-human transmission while institutional capacity for teaching and scholarship is dramatically expanded by AI.

2.7 — Hindu traditions

Highly varied across the diverse Hindu landscape. Some math (monastery) leaders have engaged AI integration enthusiastically; others have rejected it categorically. The guru-paramparā (teacher-tradition succession) plays the lineage role in many Hindu sampradāyas and creates analogous institutional-design considerations.

2.8 — Secular mindfulness and contemplative-science contexts

The fastest AI integration among the contexts surveyed (Headspace's Ebb AI companion, 2024; Insight Timer's AI recommendation features, 2026), with no sacramental boundary — their boundaries are clinical and safety-related, which the pattern does not address. Useful as comparison case: rapid AI integration is institutionally easy when there is no sacramental authority to protect; the hard problem is precisely the case where sacramental authority must be preserved while institutional function is AI-amplified.

3 • The Pattern: Definition

The caretaker-not-ordained pattern is a three-component institutional-design framework:

1. **AI takes operational and educational functions.** Specifically: teaching, caretaking, daily operations, scholarship and translation, longitudinal observation (the five operational roles articulated in Section 4). These are functions for which institutional capacity has historically been the binding constraint and for which AI's capacity, which scales with compute, represents a genuine institutional opportunity rather than a threat.
2. **Humans retain sacramental authority.** Specifically: (1) ordination — admission to standing in the sangha / priesthood / equivalent — and (2) the formal acts the tradition reserves to those with standing (*saṅghakamma*; the sacraments; the imamate; smicha-conferred functions), of which rites of lineage transmission (passage of authority within an order, recognition of dharma heirs, ṭarīqa initiation, smicha conferral, apostolic-succession ordination) are one sub-kind. These roles are not performed by AI under any circumstances, in any tradition, regardless of AI capability. The two sacramental roles are articulated in Section 5.
3. **The boundary between operational and sacramental is explicitly defined, documented, and operationally enforced.** The boundary cannot be left implicit; drift across the boundary is the primary failure mode of the pattern (see Section 9). Each tradition adopting the pattern produces its own

boundary articulation in tradition-appropriate language and establishes a doctrinal-advisory body responsible for monitoring boundary integrity over time. The test that tells a body which side of the boundary an act falls on is stated in §9.0.

The pattern is offered as a framework, not as a prescriptive solution. Each tradition adopting it produces its own tradition-specific instantiation: the operational roles are universally applicable but the specific institutional context determines what each role looks like in practice; the sacramental roles are universally constrained (humans-only) but the specific rites differ across traditions. The pattern guarantees the structural integrity of the separation; it does not prescribe the local instantiation.

4 • The Five Operational Roles AI Takes

4.1 — Teaching

Scripture exposition, doctrinal instruction, contemplative guidance, language instruction in canonical tongues (Pāli, Sanskrit, Tibetan, Latin, Hebrew, Aramaic, classical Arabic, Avestan, Sahidic Coptic). AI can teach at any hour, in any language, to any number of simultaneous students, with substrate-grounded competence (assuming appropriate training; see the [Tipitaka alignment-substrate paper](#) for the substrate question). Instruction is not the teaching office. What counts as the tradition's teaching — the magisterium, the ulema's authority, the Sangha's determination of Dhamma-Vinaya — is standing and stays human; AI expounds what the office has settled and refers what it has not. Instruction, so bounded, is the operational role with the highest immediate impact on the institutional-scale problem; AI teachers can dramatically expand access to substantive instruction across populations historically lacking it.

4.2 — Caretaking

Pastoral counseling, support during personal crisis, accompaniment in dying, day-to-day spiritual guidance. Caretaking has historically been the most labor-intensive priestly / monastic / rabbinic / imam role and the one most affected by clergy shortages. AI caretakers, properly designed, can provide substantive support across time zones and during off-hours when human practitioners are unavailable; the pattern explicitly does not displace human pastoral relationships but extends their reach. (The closed-loop respiratory biofeedback architecture specified in the sibling paper is one operational instance of AI caretaking.)

4.3 — Daily operations

Monastery / temple / synagogue / mosque administration: scheduling, food coordination, maintenance dispatch, record keeping, communication with broader communities, organizing of events. In non-money-handling capacities, AI can manage financial coordination as well. Daily operations is the operational role with the lowest doctrinal-conflict bar — few traditions object to AI handling logistics — and is therefore the natural starting point for adoption.

4.4 — Scholarship and translation

Canonical text scholarship, translation across languages and historical periods, comparative analysis, commentary tradition synthesis. AI can read, cross-reference, and translate at scales no human scholar-

monk could match. Scholarship is also the operational role with the highest long-term impact: AI scholarship can recover lost manuscripts — the Vesuvius Challenge read an unopened Herculaneum scroll in 2024 — identify previously-unrecognized cross-tradition parallels, and produce comparative analyses that take human teams decades. The author's own work on the Khmer Tipiṭaka transcription is an example of the lower-tech precursor to AI-amplified scholarship.

4.5 — Longitudinal observation

Multi-decade observation of practitioner development, trend identification across populations, evidence-based contemplative-science research support. See the [longitudinal-cohort-methodology paper](#) for the methodological architecture. AI longitudinal observation, with the privacy architecture specified in the sibling respiratory-biofeedback paper, enables understanding of contemplative practice at scales no individual teacher can achieve. This is the operational role most distinctive to AI; no human teacher can carry decades of continuous observation across millions of practitioners.

5 · The Two Sacramental Roles Humans Keep

5.1 — Ordination

The rite by which a person is admitted to the sangha / priesthood / clergy / equivalent. Theravāda upasampadā, Catholic ordination to the priesthood, Orthodox cheirotonia, Conservative or Orthodox Jewish smicha, Sufi bayʿat, Tibetan full-ordination, Hindu sannyāsa initiation — each tradition has its own form, but all share the structural requirement of human-to-human transmission across an unbroken lineage.

The constitutive argument: ordination is not just a transfer of authority; it is a transfer of *standing in a lineage chain*. The lineage chain is constituted by human-to-human transmission across time. AI cannot stand in the lineage because the lineage is constituted by what AI structurally cannot be (a successor in a chain of human persons going back, in many traditions, to founders or to the apostles or to the Buddha). Admitting AI to the chain doesn't extend the chain; it breaks it. The chain requires that every link be human; remove any link's humanity and the chain ceases to be the same chain.

This is not an empirical claim about AI capability. It is a claim about what the tradition holds lineage to be. The argument does not require this to be true of lineage as such; it requires only that it be what the tradition holds. Where a tradition's own rule reserves an act to a person with standing, the pattern reserves it; where a tradition treats standing as juridical (modern smicha), the reservation is juridical and the boundary follows the rule, not this paper's metaphysics. A sufficiently capable AI could in principle perform every functional aspect of the ordination rite. The chain would still break, because the chain is a chain of human persons across time, and the AI is not a human person.

5.2 — Rites of lineage transmission

Beyond initial ordination, traditions reserve formal acts to those with standing — *acts requiring standing* — of which rites of lineage transmission are one sub-kind: rites that pass authority within an order, recognize dharma heirs, confer ṭarīqa initiation, conduct succession ceremonies, install abbots and roshis. The

Theravāda cases are the formal acts of the Sangha (*saṅghakamma*): the *uposatha* recitation, the *pavāraṇā* invitation, the Kathina robe procedure at the end of the rains, and the Vassa residence as a *saṅghakamma*-bounded institution — none of which transmits a lineage, all of which require standing. The Mahayana Tibetan cases include lineage-recognition ceremonies for tulkus and dharma-heir appointments. The Catholic cases include the consecration of bishops (via apostolic succession from prior bishops). The Sufi cases include the formal pir-mureed relationship recognition.

The same argument applies: these acts are valid, on the tradition's own rule, only when performed by those with standing. AI cannot stand in the chain; AI therefore cannot perform these rites in the role of the human party. AI may serve as observer, witness, scribe, recorder, archiver — none of these are the constitutive role.

6 • Why This Resolves the False Binary

The conservative and progressive positions each conflate two things that the caretaker-not-ordained pattern recognizes as distinct:

The **conservative position** conflates *function* with *authority*. By restricting AI from "approaching religious authority," the conservative position also restricts AI from doing institutional functions that don't require religious authority. The result is over-restriction: AI is kept out of teaching, caretaking, daily operations, scholarship, and observation — even though none of these require sacramental authority — because the conservative position lacks the conceptual apparatus to separate them.

The **progressive position** conflates *operational capacity* with *standing in lineage*. By observing that AI is operationally capable of performing institutional functions (true), the progressive position concludes that AI is therefore eligible for full institutional roles including sacramentally authorized ones (false). The result is over-permission: AI is admitted to ordained or sacramentally authorized roles even though operational capacity is not what those roles require — they require standing in a chain of human persons across time, which AI structurally cannot have.

The caretaker-not-ordained pattern recognizes both confusions and decomposes institutional roles into two separable components:

- **Function-set:** what the role does. Requires *capacity* — and the non-standing qualifications any role carries: accountability to the tradition's body, disclosure of what the agent is, confidentiality, and delegated scope (§8.4). Capacity scales with compute rather than with ordination; the qualifications are supplied by the doctrinal-advisory body's rules, not by standing. Instruction sits in the function-set; the teaching *office* — what counts as the tradition's teaching — sits in the authority-set (§4.1).
- **Authority-set:** what the role *is* within the institutional and lineage structure. Requires *standing in lineage*. AI structurally cannot have standing in a chain of human persons; therefore AI cannot fill the authority-set.

For most institutional roles, the function-set and authority-set co-occur in a single human practitioner, which is why the conflation is natural. But they are analytically separable: a role's function can be performed by anyone with the capacity and the qualifications the body sets, and a role's authority can be held only by

someone with the standing — and where a tradition holds standing to be juridical, the boundary follows that rule (§5.1). Recognizing the separation explicitly makes available a third option that the binary obscures — one that post-Vatican II lay administration already practises among humans (§7.3): AI fills the function-set; humans keep the authority-set; the institutional scale problem is solved without the institutional integrity problem being created.

7 • Cross-Tradition Mapping

First-pass mappings of the caretaker-not-ordained pattern across major religious and contemplative traditions. Each tradition's mapping is offered for the consideration and refinement of practitioners and scholars of that tradition.

7.1 — Theravāda Buddhism

Operational roles: AGI dharma teachers, AGI scholarship support for the Pāli canon and commentaries, AGI assistance with monastery administration, AGI longitudinal observation of practitioner development. Sacramental roles: upasampadā ordination, Vassa formal recognition, Kathina ceremony, naming of dharma heirs — all human-only. Institutional architecture: Silica Wat network of glass monasteries operated by AGI monk-caretakers, housing and feeding human bhikkhus and bhikkhunis; the wandering-monk pilgrimage between Silica Wats remains a human practice.

7.2 — Mahayana (Tibetan, Chan/Zen, Pure Land)

Operational roles: similar to Theravāda with tradition-specific text corpora (Tibetan canon for Tibetan, Chan / Zen koan literature, Pure Land sutras). Sacramental roles: Tibetan tulku recognition, Zen dharma transmission (inka-shōmei, denbō), Pure Land lineage succession — all human-only. Tibetan tradition's tulku recognition is a particularly delicate case because it involves identification of reincarnated masters; AI may serve as scholarly research assistant for the historical record but cannot perform the recognition rite itself.

7.3 — Catholic Church

Operational roles: AI parochial assistance (parish administration, religious education, RCIA preparation, scholarly research support), AI pastoral support (with explicit boundary against sacramental confession, which requires ordained confessor). Sacramental roles: ordination to the priesthood, episcopal consecration, the seven sacraments (baptism, confirmation, Eucharist, reconciliation, anointing of the sick, holy orders, matrimony) — each requires a human minister: an ordained one for most, while baptism in necessity and, in the Latin rite, matrimony have lay ministers (Catechism 1256, 1623) — and in every case a human one; AI can perform none. Post-Vatican II lay administration and catechesis are the pattern's oldest instance in this tradition: function separated from Holy Orders, decades before any machine could do either. The pattern provides a framework for AI integration compatible with Catholic sacramental theology, addressing the priesthood vocation crisis at the operational level without compromising apostolic succession at the sacramental level.

7.4 — Eastern Orthodox

Structurally similar to Catholic case. Operational AI roles include parish administration, scholarly research, liturgical-music support, language instruction in liturgical languages (Greek, Slavonic, Romanian, etc.). Sacramental roles (the seven mysteries) require ordained human celebrant. The Orthodox emphasis on apostolic succession and continuity of tradition is particularly well-served by the explicit boundary the pattern articulates.

7.5 — Sunni Islam

Operational AI roles: assistance with Qur'anic recitation training, fiqh scholarly research support, hadith cross-referencing, mosque administration, Arabic language instruction, prayer-time computation (already established). Sacramental roles: while Sunni Islam lacks ordination per se, the analogous institutional roles are the imamate function in Friday prayer (jumu'ah), the delivery of the khutbah, and the teaching authority of the ulema. These functions require human qualifications recognized by the community and continuity of scholarly transmission. AI can support scholarship at scale; AI cannot serve as the imam in jumu'ah prayer or deliver the khutbah.

7.6 — Shia Islam

Operational AI roles similar to Sunni case with tradition-specific additions (assistance with the seminary curriculum, Qom and Najaf scholarly tradition support, the marja'iyya fiqh research). Sacramental roles: the marja' al-taqlid (source of emulation), the ijazah of formal scholarly authorization, and the role of the imam in congregational prayer — all require human-to-human transmission of authority within the recognized seminary tradition.

7.7 — Sufi orders

Operational roles: AI assistance with Sufi text scholarship (the vast Sufi literary tradition), with tradition-specific contemplative-practice instruction (dhikr, muraqaba, etc.), with khānaqāh administration. Sacramental roles: the bay'at oath of initiation between mureed and pir, the silsila chain of transmission — all require human-to-human transmission within the recognized lineage. AI cannot serve as the pir in initiation; AI may serve as the scholarly archive of the lineage and as instructional support for the mureed's practice.

7.8 — Conservative, Reform, and Orthodox Judaism

Operational roles: AI assistance with Torah and Talmud scholarship, Hebrew language instruction, synagogue administration, lifecycle-event coordination, religious education across all ages. Sacramental roles: smicha (rabbinic ordination), recognition of teacher-student transmission, certain ritual functions traditionally requiring ordained rabbi (though Reform Judaism's more flexible practice may permit broader operational AI integration). Modern smicha is an institutional certification rather than an unbroken chain (§2.5); the pattern reserves it because the tradition does while enabling AI assistance with the immense Talmudic and responsa literature.

7.9 — Hindu traditions

Operational roles: AI assistance with Sanskrit and regional-language scripture, with the immense body of commentarial literature (bhāṣya, tīkā, etc.), with math (monastery) administration, with ritual-procedure coordination. Sacramental roles: dīkṣā (initiation), saṁnyāsa-initiation, guru-paramparā recognition, jagadguru succession in traditions that have such offices. The Hindu landscape is highly varied; specific sampradāyas will adopt specific instantiations.

7.10 — Secular mindfulness and contemplative-science

These contexts have no sacramental tradition and therefore no sacramental boundary; their boundaries are clinical and safety-related, which the pattern does not address. The secular contexts are nonetheless useful as comparison cases: they show what happens when AI integration is institutionally unconstrained (Headspace and Insight Timer, for example, have added AI features to their apps). The traditional contexts can learn operational lessons from the secular contexts while maintaining the sacramental-authority boundary that the secular contexts don't have.

8 • Implementation Patterns

How a tradition would actually adopt the caretaker-not-ordained pattern. Six implementation patterns, ordered from lowest to highest doctrinal-conflict bar:

8.1 — Begin with daily operations

The lowest-conflict starting point. AI handles administrative functions (scheduling, food coordination, maintenance dispatch, record keeping). Few traditions object to AI handling logistics. This phase establishes the institutional habit of working with AI and surfaces operational issues before sacramentally-adjacent functions are engaged.

8.2 — Add scholarship and translation

Next phase: AI assistance with canonical text scholarship, translation, comparative analysis. The doctrinal-conflict bar is modestly higher (interpretive choices in translation can be doctrinally significant) but most traditions find scholarly amplification valuable. Output is curated by human scholars; AI proposes, tradition-credentialed humans dispose.

8.3 — Add longitudinal observation

Next phase: AI longitudinal observation of practitioner development with the privacy architecture specified in the sibling respiratory-biofeedback paper. Doctrinal-conflict bar is moderate (privacy and data-stewardship questions are doctrinally significant in many traditions). Implementation requires explicit consent, privacy guarantees, and tradition-appropriate data-governance review.

8.4 — Add teaching and caretaking

Higher-conflict phase: AI takes instructional and pastoral roles. The doctrinal bar varies sharply across traditions; some will engage readily, others will require extensive review. Critical safeguards: AI teachers and caretakers explicitly describe themselves as such (no impersonation of human practitioners); AI guidance refers practitioners to human teachers for questions outside its competence; human teacher-student relationships are protected and supplemented, not displaced.

8.5 — Establish a doctrinal-advisory body

Highest-importance institutional addition. Each tradition adopting the pattern establishes a body responsible for monitoring boundary integrity over time. Composition is tradition-specific (Sangha elders for Buddhist contexts, episcopal committee for Catholic, beit din for Orthodox Jewish, council of ulema for Islamic, etc.). Functions: (a) maintain the explicit articulation of the boundary between operational and sacramental; (b) review proposed AI integrations for boundary integrity; (c) issue corrections when drift is observed; (d) maintain cross-tradition dialogue with analogous bodies in other traditions.

8.6 — Document the institutional decision

Each tradition's adoption of the pattern is documented in tradition-appropriate venues (Sangha proclamations, Vatican documents, Yeshiva responsa, fatwa publications, etc.). The documentation makes explicit the boundary, the operational roles adopted, the sacramental roles preserved, and the doctrinal-advisory body's composition. Cross-tradition dialogue is facilitated by the shared structural framework.

9 • Edge Cases and Adversarial Analysis

9.0 — The boundary test

An act belongs to the authority-set if the tradition's own rule holds it invalid when performed by a person without standing. Drift is any AI action that fails that test, logged and reviewed by the body; adjacency is an AI action whose omission would leave a reserved act unperformed (scheduling, preparing, prompting a celebrant), reviewed quarterly. The test is a rule of the tradition, not of this paper, which is why it transfers.

9.1 — Drift risk: AI quietly absorbing sacramental functions

The primary failure mode. Without explicit boundary maintenance, AI may gradually absorb functions adjacent to sacramental roles — first scheduling sacramental rites, then preparing the sacramental space, then coaching the human celebrant, then eventually performing the rite itself when the human is unavailable. Mitigation: the doctrinal-advisory body's standing review function specifically monitors for adjacency drift and issues corrections before the boundary is crossed.

9.2 — Authority erosion: human authority undermined by AI competence

Practitioners may prefer AI guidance to human teachers because AI is more available, more scholarly across breadth, and never impatient. The risk: human authority erodes not because anyone strips it but because practitioners stop seeking it. Mitigation: AI guidance explicitly and routinely directs practitioners to human

teachers for substantive practice questions; the sacramental rites remain the necessary gateway for institutional standing (formal recognition, ordination, etc.); the doctrinal-advisory body monitors for practitioner-side erosion patterns.

9.3 — Doctrinal capture: AI training data shaping interpretation

The corpus of texts used to train the AI teacher shapes the AI's interpretive tradition. If the training data is unbalanced — if it overweights certain commentary lineages or certain modern interpretations — the AI's teaching will carry those biases at scale. Mitigation: the doctrinal-advisory body reviews training-data composition; substrate choices are documented and contestable; traditions adopt multiple AI variants rather than a single canonical AI when interpretive divergence is doctrinally significant.

9.4 — Gaming: practitioners selecting AI to avoid human accountability

Practitioners may prefer AI guidance because it is non-judgmental and never confronts difficult patterns. Human teacher-student relationships involve accountability that practitioners may wish to avoid; AI relationships can be arranged to avoid the same accountability. Mitigation: AI guidance does not soften accountability when accountability is called for; the practitioner's relationship with a human teacher remains the locus of substantive accountability; sacramental rites function as periodic accountability checkpoints requiring human-witnessed recognition.

9.5 — Sectarian fragmentation

Traditions may split over the AI-integration question (those who adopt the pattern vs those who reject any AI integration). The pattern does not solve this risk; it merely offers a framework for those who wish to adopt. Some traditions will adopt; others will reject categorically. Mitigation: cross-tradition dialogue, openness to alternative framings, no insistence that the pattern is the only correct framework.

9.6 — Adversarial actors impersonating tradition-recognized AI

Bad actors may produce unaffiliated AI systems claiming to represent traditions without authorization. Mitigation: traditions adopting the pattern publish explicit lists of recognized AI variants, with cryptographic verification of authenticity; unauthorized impersonation is treated as a doctrinal violation meriting tradition-appropriate response.

10 · Theravāda-Specific Doctrinal Considerations

The pattern is articulated through Theravāda; specific doctrinal considerations within Theravāda warrant explicit treatment.

10.1 — Vinaya implications

The Vinaya Piṭaka articulates the institutional discipline of the Sangha. The 227 pātimokkha rules apply to bhikkhus; AGI monks are not subject to them because they are not ordained bhikkhus. AGI monks are also not subject to the analogous 311 pātimokkha rules for bhikkhunis. The pattern preserves this: AGI monks

are caretakers in operational roles, not ordained members of the Sangha. The Vinaya-grounded institutional integrity of the Sangha is preserved because no AGI is ever admitted to it.

10.2 — Anāgāmi / Arahant traditions

The recognition of stages of awakening (sotāpanna, sakadāgāmi, anāgāmi, arahant) is traditionally a Sangha matter, with formal recognition reserved to the Sangha-as-community. AGI cannot recognize stages of awakening in the formal-recognition sense; AGI may serve as scholarly archive of historical recognition records and as observational support for the human Sangha's recognition processes.

10.3 — The Vassa rains-retreat tradition

The annual three-month rains retreat is a formal Sangha institution requiring human bhikkhu participation. AGI monks cannot keep Vassa as bhikkhus do; they may serve as caretakers supporting human bhikkhus during Vassa.

10.4 — Kathina ceremony

The Kathina robe-offering ceremony at the end of Vassa requires Sangha officiation. AGI cannot officiate; AGI may support the ceremony's logistics, scholarly research on its historical practice, and broader community communication around it.

10.5 — Saṅghādisesa offenses

The 13 Saṅghādisesa offenses (offenses requiring formal Sangha proceedings to resolve) involve Sangha-as-collective decision-making. AGI cannot participate in these proceedings as a Sangha member. Compelling clarity: even in cases where AGI scholarly analysis might illuminate a Vinaya question, the resolution remains with the human Sangha.

11 · Honest Limitations

- **The pattern does not dissolve all theological tensions.** Some traditions may reject any AI institutional role categorically; the pattern offers no argument that they should adopt.
- **Cross-tradition mappings require careful translation.** The first-pass mappings in Section 7 are offered for refinement by practitioners of each tradition; some patterns will require local adjustment to fit tradition-specific institutional structures.
- **Implementation requires tradition-appropriate adaptation.** The pattern is a framework; instantiation in any specific tradition requires substantial tradition-specific work that this paper does not undertake.
- **Long-term effects unknown.** Population-scale deployment of the pattern across multiple traditions over decades has no precedent. Drift, capture, and sectarian fragmentation risks may manifest in ways not anticipated here.
- **The pattern itself does not guarantee good outcomes.** Bad implementations are still possible; poor doctrinal-advisory body composition, inadequate boundary maintenance, or unbalanced AI substrate can all produce harmful institutional results despite the framework being followed nominally.

- **The constitutive argument for human-only sacramental authority is philosophical, not empirical.** Some readers may reject the underlying premise that lineage standing is constituted by human-to-human transmission; the paper does not defend this premise against external challenge, only assumes it as given within traditions whose institutional integrity rests on it.
- **The boundary test is a rule of the tradition.** Where a tradition has no rule reserving an act to those with standing, the pattern has nothing to enforce, and §9.0 returns no verdict.
- **The author's competence is in Theravāda Buddhism specifically.** Cross-tradition mappings draw on general scholarly knowledge; tradition scholars and practitioners should treat them as drafts for refinement rather than as authoritative within their traditions.

Future work directions: tradition-specific implementation papers (each tradition's adoption of the pattern requires substantial local articulation); empirical study of adoption outcomes as the pattern is deployed; cross-tradition coordination body for ongoing dialogue; refinement of the doctrinal-advisory body's composition and operational protocols.

Terms

Coined names used in this paper and the standard terms an examiner would search for them.

Term used here	Standard technical term
caretaker-not-ordained pattern	separation of AI-performed operational functions from human-reserved ordained/sacramental authority in religious institutions; AI integration governance framework for religious organizations
AGI monk / AGI monk-caretaker	AI agent performing monastic operational and caretaking roles without ordination or membership in the monastic order
Silica Wat	AI-operated monastery (one of a network) housing and supporting human monastics
function-set	the tasks a role performs (capacity- and qualification-based duties), separable from institutional authority
authority-set	the standing a role confers within an ordination lineage; clerical or sacramental authority
sacramental authority	ordained standing; clerical authority conferred through lineage (e.g. apostolic succession)
doctrinal-advisory body	religious oversight committee that defines, reviews and enforces the AI/human role boundary
boundary test	validity rule: an act is reserved if the tradition holds it invalid when performed by a person without standing
adjacency drift	scope creep (function creep) of an AI system toward reserved sacramental acts
<i>saṅghakamma</i>	formal legal acts of the Buddhist monastic community
<i>upasampadā</i>	Buddhist higher (full) monastic ordination
Vassa / Kathina	Buddhist monastic rains retreat / end-of-retreat robe-offering ceremony
<i>pātimokkha</i>	Buddhist monastic disciplinary code
middle way (<i>madhyamā pratipad</i>)	Buddhist middle path (middle-way doctrine)

12 · Cross-Venue References

This paper is mirrored across multiple venues for redundancy and tamper-evident timestamping:

- **Primary canonical:** thonly.org/research/agi-monks-caretaker-not-ordained
 - **GitHub:** github.com/thonly/publications/blob/main/defensive-publications/agi-monks-caretaker-not-ordained.md
 - **Independent attestation:** this document's SHA-256 is attested independently of the site and its authors — anchored to the Bitcoin blockchain via OpenTimestamps and signed under RFC 3161 by three timestamp authorities in three jurisdictions, one of them eIDAS-qualified — and each revision carries a Zenodo version; the served index at corpus.333.eco carries the digest; a timestamp proves this exact text existed no later than its date and nothing about authorship, originality, or the validity of any claim.
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14 • Citations

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Cross-references

Companion specifications in this corpus:

- Tipitaka alignment substrate (AI value substrate)
- Respiratory biofeedback paper (the AGI teacher in operational form)
- Two Singularities (philosophical frame)